Lesson 10: Grammar Refresher: Count and Noncount Nouns and Articles

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 1: Refining Sentences and Punctuation

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 7.4: Count and Noncount Nouns and Articles; 7.12: Overview of English Grammar (Exercises).

In this lesson

You will learn to tell count nouns from noncount nouns, to express quantities of noncount nouns, and to choose between *a*, *an*, *the* and no article with the book's two article rules. You will also review prepositional phrases from Lessons 01 and 09. Articles are among the most frequent words in English, and using them correctly makes your writing about research precise and natural.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Tell count nouns from noncount nouns, including abstract nouns.
- Express a quantity of a noncount noun (some money, two pieces of furniture).
- Use *a* / *an* for one nonspecific thing and *the* for specific things.
- Apply the two article rules to edit a paragraph.
- Identify prepositional phrases (review).

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
noun	a word that names a thing, place, person or idea	desk, Chicago, woman, peace
count noun	a noun for separate units that you can count; plural with -s	three desks, two candidates
noncount noun	a noun for a whole that cannot be separated and counted; no plural, no *a* / *an*	money, furniture, sugar
concrete noun	a noun for something you can see, taste, touch or count	chocolate, soap
abstract noun	a noun for something you cannot see, touch or count; most are noncount	anger, education, peace, information
article	the words *a*, *an* and *the*	a concert, the concert
definite article	*the*: refers to one or more specific things	the woman (a particular woman)

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
indefinite article	*a* / *an*: refers to one nonspecific thing; only before a singular count noun	a woman (any woman)
determiner	a word before a noun that shows which one or how many, such as *my*, *this*, *some*, *every*	my notebook, every candidate
prepositional phrase	a preposition + a noun or pronoun (review)	throughout the summer

Rules and explanations

Count and noncount nouns

- **Count nouns** are separate units. Make them plural with -s: It takes six quarters to do my laundry. / The two candidates debated the issue.
- **Noncount nouns** are whole things that cannot be separated and counted one by one. You cannot put a number before them or add -s.

Incorrect	Correct
five moneys	some money
two furnitures	two pieces of furniture
three sugars	two teaspoons of sugar

To give a quantity, use a word like *some* or a unit + *of* (pieces of, teaspoons of). Another example from the overview exercises: millions of gallons of oil.

Type of noncount noun	Examples	Sentence
food	sugar, salt, pepper, lettuce, rice	Add more sugar to my coffee, please.
solids	concrete, chocolate, silver, soap	The ice cream was covered in creamy chocolate.
abstract nouns	peace, warmth, hospitality, information	I need more information about the insurance policy.

Most abstract nouns (anger, education, melancholy, softness, violence, conduct) are noncount, but there are some exceptions.

Articles

- **the** (definite) refers to one or more specific things. It is used before singular and plural count nouns.
- **a / an** (indefinite) refers to one nonspecific thing. It is used only before a singular count noun.

Sentence	Meaning
I saw the concert.	one specific concert
I saw the concerts.	more than one specific concert
I saw the U2 concert last night.	one specific concert
I saw a concert.	any concert, not a specific one

The two article rules

- **Rule 1:** A singular count noun needs an article or a determiner. Choose *a* or *an* if the noun is indefinite; choose *the* if it is definite.
- **Rule 2:** A plural or noncount noun does not need an article unless it is definite.

A noun is definite when the reader knows exactly which one you mean: for example, there is only one (the sun), you have mentioned it before, or words after the noun say which one.

Psychology note: in psychology (APA style), *data* is a plural count noun (These data show ...), while *research*, *evidence* and *information* are noncount: no -s and no *a*.

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Arabic has a definite article (al-) but no indefinite article, so *a* / *an* is easy to leave out ("He is student"). By Rule 1, every singular count noun needs *a*, *an*, *the* or another determiner.
> - Arabic uses its definite article for general and abstract ideas, but English does not: write *Education is important* and *Life is short*, not "The education" or "The life".

Practice

The exercises have no numbers in the lesson material; here they are numbered in order. Exercise 4 is from the overview exercises.

Exercise 1. Count or noncount? Write C (count) or NC (noncount) for the noun in bold. (The lesson material asks about the "italicized" noun, but the italics are missing there.)

1. The amount of **traffic** on the way home was terrible.
2. **Forgiveness** is an important part of growing up.
3. I made caramel sauce for the organic **apples** I bought.
4. I prefer film **cameras** instead of digital ones.
5. My favorite subject is **history**.
6. "**Freedom** is just another word for nothing left to lose."

Exercise 2. Articles. Write the correct article for each sentence.

1. (A/An/The) camel can live for days without water.
2. I enjoyed (a/an/the) pastries at the Bar Mitzvah. (A Bar Mitzvah is a Jewish coming-of-age ceremony.)

3. (A/An/The) politician spoke of many important issues.
4. I really enjoyed (a/an/the) actor's performance in the play.
5. (A/An/The) goal I have is to run a marathon this year.

Exercise 3. A paragraph about stars. Correct the misused or missing articles in the paragraph in the lesson material that begins "Stars are large balls of spinning hot gas like our sun." Then rewrite the paragraph.

Exercise 4. Review: prepositional phrases (overview Exercise 3). Underline the prepositional phrase in each sentence.

1. Monica told us about her trip.
2. I hope we have sunshine throughout the summer.
3. The panther climbed up the tree.
4. The little boy was standing behind his mother's legs.
5. We stayed awake until dawn.

More items: overview Exercises 1, 2, 4, 5 and 6 in the lesson material practise subject-verb agreement, verb forms and tenses, questions, adjective order and negatives, which this course does not teach. Your tutor can check them if you do them.

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me fifteen nouns from psychology, such as memory, research, behavior, data, evidence, emotion and sleep. I will say count or noncount and make a sentence with each. Correct me."
- "Here is a paragraph I wrote: [paste]. Mark only the article errors with a number. I will correct them myself, and then you check."
- "In Live conversation, ask me to describe my room or my study routine. Listen for *a*, *an*, *the* and plural -s, and tell me my three most frequent errors."
- "Check my answers to overview Exercises 1, 2, 4, 5 and 6 in the lesson material: [paste]."

Read aloud

Say *a* quickly and weakly (like "uh"). Say *the* like "thuh" before a consonant sound and like "thee" before a vowel sound.

1. A camel can live for days without water.
2. I need more information about the insurance policy.
3. Did you know that the Milky Way galaxy has between two hundred billion and four hundred billion stars in it?
4. Scientists estimate that there may be as many as five hundred billion galaxies in the ("thee") entire universe!
5. A star is born in a cloud of cosmic gas and dust called a nebula.
6. I really enjoyed the ("thee") actor's performance in the play.

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 150 to 200 words that explains a general topic in science, in the style of the paragraph about stars. Choose one:

- a topic from nature, like the book's paragraph (for example the moon, volcanoes or bees);
- a topic from PSYC 110, for example how memory works, or what happens to the brain during sleep.

Include at least three noncount nouns (for example *information*, *research*, *sleep*), one quantity phrase (a piece of information, eight hours of sleep), general plural nouns, and at least one noun that you mention first with *a* / *an* and later with *the*.

Checklist:

- Every singular count noun has *a*, *an*, *the* or another determiner (Rule 1).
- General plural and noncount nouns have no article (Rule 2).
- I used *the* only when the reader knows which one: there is only one, I mentioned it before, or words after the noun say which one.
- Noncount nouns have no -s and no *a* / *an* (information, research, evidence).
- A quantity of a noncount noun uses a unit + *of*.
- If I used *data*, it has a plural verb (the data show).

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

The book gives no key; these answers follow the book's rules.

Exercise 1

1. NC
2. NC (an abstract noun)
3. C (*caramel sauce* in the same sentence is NC.)
4. C
5. NC (an abstract noun: a school subject)
6. NC (an abstract noun)

Exercise 2

1. A (any camel). *The* is also possible in formal writing when you mean the whole species: The camel can live for days without water.
2. the (specific pastries: the ones at that Bar Mitzvah; *a* cannot go before a plural noun)
3. A (first mention: some politician the reader does not know). *The* is correct if the reader already knows which politician.
4. the (a specific actor: the one in that play)
5. The (the goal: the words *I have* say which one). *A* is also correct if you mean one of several goals.

Exercise 3 (changes in bold) Stars are large balls of spinning hot gas like our sun. **Stars** look tiny because they are far away. Many of them are much larger than **the** sun. Did you know that **the** Milky Way galaxy has between two hundred billion and four hundred billion stars in it? Scientists estimate that there may be as many as five hundred billion galaxies in **the** entire universe! Just like a human being, **a** star has a life cycle from birth to death, but its lifespan is billions of years long. **A** star is born in a cloud of cosmic gas and dust called a nebula. Our sun was born in **a** nebula nearly five billion years ago. Photographs of star-forming nebulas are astonishing.

- *Stars look tiny*: a general statement (Rule 2). *The stars look tiny* is also acceptable if you mean the stars we see in the night sky.
- *the sun*, *the Milky Way*, *the entire universe*: there is only one. (*than our sun* is also correct.)
- *a star* (twice), *a nebula*: any star, any nebula (Rule 1). *A star* also matches *a human being*.
- *Photographs of star-forming nebulas*: a general plural, so no article (Rule 2).

Exercise 4

1. about her trip
2. throughout the summer
3. up the tree
4. behind his mother's legs
5. until dawn

My notes